



# PROVIDENCE ENGLISH PRIVATE SCHOOL

## Social Media Policy

### 2026 – 2027

*To raise students' awareness of safe and responsible use of social media.*

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| <b>Document Title</b>       | Social Media Policy                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Academic Year</b>        | 2026 – 2027                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Document Owner</b>       | IT Coordinator, in coordination with the Student Counsellor and Child Protection Coordinator                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Approved By</b>          | Principal and Governing Body                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Last Reviewed</b>        | September 2026                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Next Review</b>          | September 2027                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Directed Towards</b>     | All Students (Primary awareness programme from Year 4; full policy scope Year 4 – Year 13)                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Linked Policies</b>      | Digital Citizenship Policy; BYOD Policy; Anti-Bullying Policy; Anti-Discrimination & Anti-Violence Policy; Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy; Data Protection & Privacy Policy; Behaviour & Discipline Policy; Parent-School Communication Policy |
| <b>Regulatory Framework</b> | UAE Federal Decree-Law No. 34 of 2021 on Combating Rumours and Cybercrimes; UAE Federal Law No. 3 of 2016 on Child Rights ("Wadeema's Law"); Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA); UAE Ministry of Education (MOE)                               |

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## 1. Purpose & Objectives

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Social media plays an increasingly significant role in the lives of children and young people. This policy exists to raise students' awareness of safe and responsible use of social media, both during school hours and beyond, helping them develop the knowledge and judgement to use these platforms positively and safely.

The objectives of this policy are to:

- Help students understand the benefits and the risks of social media use;
- Build students' awareness of privacy, digital footprint, and online reputation;
- Equip students to recognise and respond appropriately to cyberbullying, inappropriate contact, and other online risks;
- Set clear expectations for social media use in connection with the school community;
- Provide a clear route for students to report a concern and receive support.

## 2. Scope

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This policy applies to all PEPS students and covers the use of social media both on and off school premises, where that use relates to, affects, or involves members of the school community. It applies alongside the school's Digital Citizenship Policy, which covers the broader use of technology and devices, and the BYOD Policy, which governs personal devices brought to school.

While much social media use takes place outside school hours and outside the school's direct supervision, PEPS has a role in educating students about safe use and in responding where online conduct affects the wellbeing of a student or the school community, in line with Section 13.

## 3. Legal & Regulatory Framework

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This policy is written with reference to:

- UAE Federal Decree-Law No. 34 of 2021 on Combating Rumours and Cybercrimes, which addresses online harassment, defamation, and the misuse of digital platforms;
- UAE Federal Law No. 3 of 2016 concerning Child Rights ("Wadeema's Law"), which protects children from harm, including online harm;
- Guidance from the Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA) and the UAE Ministry of Education (MOE) on e-safety and student wellbeing.

## 4. Definitions

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- Social media refers to websites and applications that enable users to create and share content and to participate in social networking, including but not limited to Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok, X, Facebook, YouTube, and messaging or gaming platforms with social features.
- Digital footprint means the trail of data a person leaves behind through their online activity, including posts, comments, photos, and interactions, which can be difficult or impossible to fully remove.
- Cyberbullying means the use of digital platforms to repeatedly and intentionally harass, threaten, humiliate, or exclude another person.

## 5. Guiding Principles

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- Education, not just restriction: PEPS believes the most effective protection is helping students understand risks and make good choices, alongside appropriate safeguards.
- Age-appropriateness: awareness education is adapted to the age and maturity of students at each stage.
- Shared responsibility: safe social media use is a partnership between the school, parents, and students themselves.
- Support over blame: students who make a mistake or experience harm online are supported, not shamed, when they come forward.
- Consistency: this policy is applied alongside, not instead of, the school's Anti-Bullying, Safeguarding, and Behaviour & Discipline Policies.

## 6. Age Restrictions & Platform Minimum Ages

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Most social media platforms set a minimum age for creating an account, typically 13, in line with international data protection standards; some platforms recommend a higher age. PEPS supports parents in enforcing these minimum ages and does not encourage or facilitate social media use by students below a platform's stated minimum age.

An illustrative (non-exhaustive) list of commonly used platforms and their typical minimum ages is provided in Appendix A; parents should always check the current terms of the specific platform, as these can change.

## 7. Safe & Responsible Use — General Expectations

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Students are encouraged to:

- Only use social media platforms appropriate to their age;
- Think before posting — consider whether content is kind, honest, and something they would be comfortable with a teacher, parent, or future employer seeing;
- Use privacy settings to control who can see their posts and personal information;
- Be respectful towards others online, just as they would be in person;
- Take regular breaks from social media and balance online activity with other interests, sleep, and family time;
- Speak to a trusted adult if something online makes them feel uncomfortable, worried, or unsafe.

## 8. Privacy & Personal Information

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Students are taught not to share personal information — such as their home address, school name and location, phone number, daily routine, or location in real time — publicly on social media, and to be cautious about how much personal information they reveal even to people they believe they know online.

## 9. Digital Footprint & Online Reputation

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Students are helped to understand that what they post online can remain accessible long after it is posted, can be copied or shared beyond their control, and can affect how they are seen by others, including in the future.

(for example, by universities or employers). Students are encouraged to pause and think before posting, commenting, or sharing content.

## 10. Cyberbullying & Online Conduct

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Cyberbullying is treated as seriously as any other form of bullying and is addressed under the school's Anti-Bullying Policy and, where relevant, the Anti-Discrimination & Anti-Violence Policy. Students are taught to:

- Never send or forward hurtful, threatening, or embarrassing messages or images about another person;
- Recognise that being part of a group chat that targets someone is a form of participation in bullying, not a neutral bystander role;
- Save evidence (screenshots) of any cyberbullying they experience or witness, and report it to a trusted adult;
- Never retaliate to unkind behaviour online, and instead seek help from a parent, teacher, or the Student Counsellor.

## 11. Sharing Content, Photos & Consent

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Students are taught to seek permission before posting a photo, video, or personal information about another person, including classmates, and to respect a request to remove content that features them without consent. Sharing intimate, embarrassing, or private images or information about another person without consent is treated as a serious breach of this policy and may also constitute a safeguarding concern and/or a criminal offence under UAE law.

## 12. Contact with Strangers & Online Safety Risks

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Students are taught to be cautious about accepting friend/follow requests or messages from people they do not know in real life, to never arrange to meet an online contact in person without a trusted adult's knowledge and involvement, and to recognise and report any contact that feels inappropriate, manipulative, or makes them uncomfortable, in line with the school's Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy.

## 13. Social Media & School-Related Content

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Students should not use social media during lesson time, and should not post content that identifies, disparages, or embarrasses another student or a member of staff, or that could damage the reputation of the school. Any social media activity that constitutes bullying, harassment, or discrimination against a member of the school community — even where it takes place outside school hours — is addressed under this policy and the relevant linked policies, where it has a clear impact on the school community or a student's wellbeing.

Only the school's official social media accounts represent PEPS publicly; students and parents should refer to the Parent-School Communication Policy for guidance on engaging with these official accounts.

## 14. Curriculum & Awareness Education

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PEPS delivers age-appropriate social media and online safety education through the pastoral/PSHE curriculum, assemblies, and awareness campaigns (for example, during Safer Internet Day), and reviews this content periodically to keep pace with new platforms and emerging risks.

## 15. Reporting a Concern

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Students who experience or witness a concerning situation on social media — whether cyberbullying, unwanted contact, or something that makes them feel unsafe — are encouraged to tell a trusted adult straight away: a parent, a teacher, their Section Supervisor, or the Student Counsellor. No student will be penalised for reporting a genuine concern in good faith. See Appendix B for a quick-reference guide.

## 16. The Role of Parents

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Parents play a central role in supervising and guiding their child's social media use outside school. Parents are encouraged to be aware of which platforms their child uses, to use parental controls and privacy settings where appropriate, to talk openly with their child about their online life, and to contact the school promptly if they become aware of an online concern involving another student or the school community.

## 17. The Role of Staff

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Staff reinforce safe social media habits through the curriculum and everyday interactions with students, respond promptly and sensitively to any disclosure or concern raised by a student, and follow the school's Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy where a concern indicates a risk to a student's safety or wellbeing. Staff do not connect with or follow current students on personal social media accounts, in line with the Digital Citizenship Policy.

## 18. Consequences of Misuse

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Where a student's social media conduct breaches this policy — for example, through cyberbullying, sharing content without consent, or posting content that harms another member of the school community — the matter is addressed under the Behaviour & Discipline Policy and, where relevant, the Anti-Bullying Policy or Anti-Discrimination & Anti-Violence Policy. Where conduct may constitute a criminal offence under UAE law, the school may also involve the relevant authorities.

The school's response is proportionate and considers the student's age, intent, and whether the behaviour was a one-off or a pattern, consistent with the approach set out in the Behaviour & Discipline Policy.

## 19. Monitoring & Policy Review

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This policy is monitored by the IT Coordinator and Student Counsellor, and reviewed periodically by the Vice Principal to ensure it remains relevant to the platforms and risks students actually encounter.

## Appendix A: Illustrative Minimum Ages by Platform

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*Ages shown are the platforms' own stated minimums at the time of writing and may change; parents should always check current platform terms directly.*

| Platform              | Typical Stated Minimum Age                 |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Instagram             | 13                                         |
| TikTok                | 13                                         |
| Snapchat              | 13                                         |
| X (Twitter)           | 13                                         |
| Facebook              | 13                                         |
| YouTube (own account) | 13 (with additional restrictions under 18) |
| WhatsApp              | 13 (16 in some regions)                    |
| Discord               | 13                                         |

## Appendix B: What To Do If Something Goes Wrong

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If something happens online that worries you, upsets you, or makes you feel unsafe:

- Don't reply or retaliate — screenshot it if you can, and stop engaging.
- Tell a trusted adult straight away — a parent, teacher, Section Supervisor, or the Student Counsellor. You will not be in trouble for telling someone.
- Block or report the account or content using the platform's own reporting tools, with an adult's help if needed.
- Remember it is never your fault if someone else behaves unkindly or inappropriately towards you online.

*This appendix should be read alongside the Anti-Bullying Policy and the Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy.*